

the request from a cached copy of unchanged pages, and improves response time. Configuration options let you tweak what to cache, and what not to. The minimum requirement is WordPress version 3.1.

Captcha

As per Wikipedia, Captcha stands for 'Completely Automated Public Turing test to tell Computers and Humans Apart'. This plug-in ensures that all comments on the site are entered by a human, by including a math puzzle on the page that a human brain must solve before entering the answer. This prevents spam bots from posting comments on the site. The minimum required is WordPress version 3.1.

Digg Digg

We definitely want to share information on our blogs through social media channels. This plug-in adds that capability for various social media sites like Facebook, Twitter and Buzz. Users that click the enabled social media icon will be prompted to share the current blog on their social networking profiles. Various social media buttons can be enabled via the settings. The minimum required is WordPress version 2.3.

Hitcounter

To count how many people have visited your blog, use the 'hitcounter' plug-in. It stores and retrieves the count from a database and displays it on the blog. The WordPress version required is 2.3, or later.

Statpress Visitors

This is one of the most useful plug-ins for statistics, beyond those of Hitcounter. Some of the details it collects includes information on visitors, robots from Google or other search engines; keywords in search engines; browser types and various other traffic to your site. It is highly customisable, with variables for various types of statistics. The minimum required is WordPress version 2.5.

TinyMCE Advanced

This plug-in provides a WYSIWYG (What You See Is What You Get) editor with extended text-editing features that the standard WordPress editor may not have. The options let you drag and drop text-editing buttons to the toolbar above the editor area. The minimum requirement for this plug-in is WordPress version 3.1.

Comment Rating

This plug-in lets users rate the comments for a particular blog, through the use of 'like' and 'dislike' buttons. The most-liked comments are displayed accordingly. The rating is also displayed beside each comment. The plug-in allows only one vote per IP address, and tries to prevent fraud. Various customisable options can be explored. The minimum requirement is WordPress version 2.3.

WordPress Automatic Online Backup

The best way to avoid losing your blog is to back it up online. A free online account at WordPressbackup.com provides you the necessary space; this plug-in provides the necessary infrastructure to automate this process. Backups can be restored at any time. I recommend this plug-in for all those who value their data. The minimum required is WordPress version 2.1.

PicasaWeb

If you need to upload pictures to your blog, the ideal way is to upload them to a cloud service like Google Picasa, and then display albums on your blog. The Google API is used to retrieve pictures from an album; plug-in settings determine which album to display. The minimum requirement is WordPress version 2.7.

All-in-One SEO Pack

The best way to attract visitors to your blog is to make it visible to a search engine. This plug-in does everything to optimise your blog in order to make it visible to a search engine and attract visitors. The minimum requirement is WordPress version 2.8.

Coding a new plug-in

If you think the existing plug-ins do not meet your specific requirements, you can pretty much code your own. Check the link in *References* for instructions.

Submitting your plug-in to the community

If you think your new plug-in offers generic functionality and can be used by many others, you can submit it to the WordPress community. After all, the huge database of WordPress plug-ins was built by millions of enthusiastic developers like you and me. Again, check *References* for a how-to. 

References

- Plug-ins Directory: <http://wordpress.org/extend/plugins/>
- How to write a new plug-in: http://codex.wordpress.org/Writing_a_Plugin
- Submitting a new plug-in: http://codex.WordPress.org/Plugin_Submission_and_Promotion

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By: Surya Prabhakar

The author is an engineering advisor in the Product Group at the Dell India R&D Centre, Bengaluru, and has eight years of experience in Linux. He spends most of his time hacking and playing around with Linux. He can be reached at surya_prabhakar@dell.com.